

Holmes: Ethics Reflection Essay

Dennis Gahm

SU25_AT5540

Bronoske

Concept 1

Ethical Egoism is not true

Own life and personal ministry

Ethical Egoism is an attractive theory. The reason is, America is largely based on it due to its adherence to individualism. Also, my life has always been a lonely journey (not completely true because I have a great family, and because of my mental illness, I've received lots of support), and so I find that finding what is best for me, even at the expense of others, is a good way of deciding what to do. I find that, from my life experience, it is always important to do what I feel is best because if I don't, I'll have regret or grudges.

I see that in my personal ministry, I have to prioritize myself as well. I cannot do absolutely *everything* for my congregation - I need to balance my time, and give myself breaks. But at the same time, of course, I cannot be selfish.

Why this is key concept in Christian Ethics and Ministry

Thus, it is important to find out how selfish a person should be. By studying egoism, I realize, "Is it good to be selfish." And the true answer is not, "All theories other than Christian Ethics is wrong" - the true answer is we have to balance all these theories and handle the truth without being ashamed (as said in Timothy in the Bible).

Concept 2

Utilitarianism is Ungodly!

Why this is key concept in Christian Ethics and Ministry

One of the things that I dislike about teachings about utilitarianism, is that many teach that utilitarianism is ungodly and atheistic. And I understand why that is the case - Stuart Mill

and all these people who created utilitarianism, were essentially fundamentally atheists and were atheistic in their theories. However, the essential concept of utilitarianism, which is to help as many people as possibly - or more specifically, have the best outcome in terms of utility - is not only reasonable, but can even be exactly what God wants.

The simple question I can ask to determine if God's will is - in some sense - utilitarian is: "Does God want what is very good, or does he want the best?" And we know that since God is perfect, he demands perfection and the best. And since God can create the perfect utility function, he will always be able to determine in his mind, what the best course of action is.

Now the question is "Is utility always superficial and disgustingly practical instead of deontological or principle-based?" And I see the most utility is usually Machiavellian, but utility can be defined in any way - including the deontological.

Own life and personal ministry

Now, in my life, I find that in all situations, I have to evaluate what is the best thing to do. Even a deontological approach to life requires this evaluation because there is no perfect rulebook of what to do in many real world situations. Also, the fact is, there are many options to take, and we don't know which one is the best. As the Bible puts it, "We look in a mirror dimly." Thus, in personal ministry, I cannot say, "I've found the Christian Ethic! I know what to do at every moment and I can be perfect ethically!" The conflict and tension is still there, and I need to balance the Bible with my critical academic thinking.

Concept 3

Agape - Christian Ethics

Why this is key concept in Christian Ethics and Ministry

I see that Agape love and Christian Ethics is very important. Many atheists and many philosophers like Aristotle can come up with theories and mind-puzzles that question what is the best thing to do for society and how to rule, but only the Bible may actually impart the life-giving truths that actually make a difference in society. And this is an important point - is Christian Ethics' purpose to make this world good or is it to make the kingdom of heaven (which is not of this world) good?

This is such an important point, and I must emphasize it. I think that ministry will always have to balance the church's and ministry's practical worldly impact and involvement with its spiritual and holy task. Yes, the church needs to pay the bills, and it needs to calculate how to be practical and effective in things such as how to get offerings; but in the end, the truth is, only the spiritual will last forever into eternity.

Own life and personal ministry

I see that Agape love is the most important Ethical principle we can have. Agape love essentially says, "How can I sacrifice my egoism or personal interests for the sake of others." It does not stem from a desire to begrudgingly do things, it stems from a true love that wants to do anything possible in order to make the other feel loved.

This is important in relationships and in marriage and family. This is important in ministry because agape love is not calculative, it is the truth that we need in good ministry that is heavenly pleasing.